



BE READY.

Pre-season

Your sessions

Muscle development

Program

Pre-season

Duration

8 weeks

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Home

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goal

You chose a single goal: every session gives it two blocks, and the focus changes over the weeks. What you worked on before stays in the sessions, with fewer sets, so you do not lose it.

Muscle development

In handball, you take contacts in every attack and every defence. Stronger muscles protect your joints and make you harder to knock off balance.

- **Strength:** pushing, pulling and lifting heavier.
- **Mass gain:** building muscle size.
- **Core and stability:** transferring force from your legs to your arm and staying stable in contacts.

The golden rules

- **Technique first:** a load only goes up if the movement stays clean.
- **Progress a little every week:** one more rep, or a slightly heavier load.
- **Control the descent:** 2 to 3 seconds down, then back up with energy.
- Keep 2 to 3 reps in reserve: never train to failure.

Mass gain: training sends the signal, but muscles are built with food and sleep. Eat enough, with protein at every meal, and sleep 8 hours. For nutrition advice, see a registered dietitian.

At home: without heavy loads, the exercise gets harder when you slow down the descent, add a weighted backpack or switch to one leg. This is why there are more reps.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Weeks 1-2 · Getting started

Get your body used to effort again and learn the movements. Effort 5-6 out of 10.

Muscle development only: the whole body in every session, light loads to learn the movements.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

9	 Squat	2-3 × 15 · 3 s descent	75 s
10	 Reverse lunge	2 × 12 per leg · 3 s descent	60 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

11	 Push-ups	2-3 × 10	60 s
12	 Inverted row	2-3 × 12	60 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

15	 Romanian deadlift	2-3 × 10 per leg	75 s
16	 Hip thrust	2-3 × 15	75 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

17	 Pike push-ups	2-3 × 10	60 s
18	 Plank with shoulder taps	2 × 10 per side	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

22	 Bulgarian split squat (with a backpack)	2 × 10 per leg · 3 s descent	60 s
23	 Farmer's walk	2 × 20 m	60 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

24	 Pull-ups (or row)	2-3 × 5-8	90 s
11	 Push-ups	2 × 10	60 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
27	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week after week, you can add the optional bonus session:

Session D (bonus, optional) - 20 min

1 WARM-UP

10 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

5	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3	60 s
28	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
29	 Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 10 per side	
30	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 3-5 - Building up

Increase the loads gradually. Week 5 is the heaviest. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Muscle development only: this is the key phase, increase the loads every week. For mass gain, do 8 to 12 reps with 60 to 90 s of rest.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

9	 Squat	3-4 × 9-12 · 3 s descent	2 min
10	 Reverse lunge	3 × 12 per leg · 3 s descent	90 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

11	 Push-ups	3-4 × 8	90 s
12	 Inverted row	3-4 × 10	90 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

16	 Hip thrust	3-4 × 12	90 s
15	 Romanian deadlift	3 × 8 per leg	90 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

24	 Pull-ups (or row)	3-4 × 6-8	90 s
17	 Pike push-ups	3 × 8	75 s
18	 Plank with shoulder taps	3 × 10 per side	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

22	 Bulgarian split squat (with a backpack)	3 × 10 per leg · 3 s descent	90 s
23	 Farmer's walk	3 × 20 m	60 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

31	 Weighted push-ups	3 × 15	90 s
12	 Inverted row	3 × 12	75 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
27	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 6-7 · Intensity

Less volume, more speed: every rep at maximum quality. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Muscle development only: fewer sets, loads still heavy, to keep what you have built without getting tired before the season starts.

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1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
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4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

9	 Squat	3 × 7 · 3 s descent	2 min
10	 Reverse lunge	2 × 9 per leg · 3 s descent	90 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

11	 Push-ups	3 × 8	75 s
12	 Inverted row	3 × 10	75 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · LOWER BODY

15-20 min

16	 Hip thrust	3 × 9	90 s
15	 Romanian deadlift	2 × 6 per leg	90 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT · UPPER BODY AND TRUNK

15-20 min

24	 Pull-ups (or row)	3 × 6	90 s
18	 Plank with shoulder taps	2 × 10 per side	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
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5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
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5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week 8 · Taper

Repeat sessions A, B and C from weeks 6-7 doing **half the sets**, at the same intensity. You will start the season with your club in top shape.

- **Muscle development:** Same loads.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

Light jog, alternating side shuffles, high knees and butt kicks.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



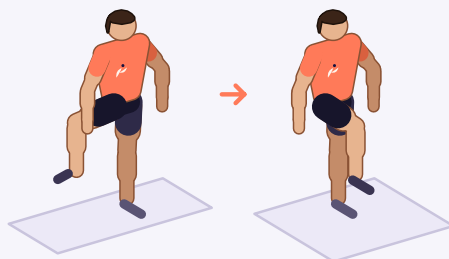
2



Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Arms straight out in front of you, take a big step forward and lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk and arms towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3



Walking hip opener

On the spot or walking: lift your knee out to the side as if stepping over a fence, bring it round in front of you at the same height, then put your foot down. Switch legs.

Key points: Upright trunk, big circle with the knee.



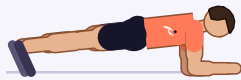
4



Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



5



Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



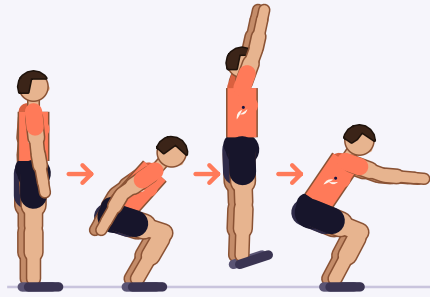
6



Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, the other foot off the floor behind you, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



7



Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

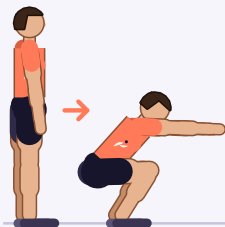
8

Progressive accelerations

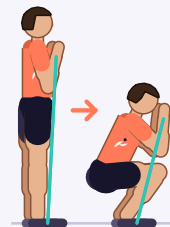
Run 15 m, building up speed: 60 %, then 80 %, then 90 % of your top speed. Walk back.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

At home



With a band



9



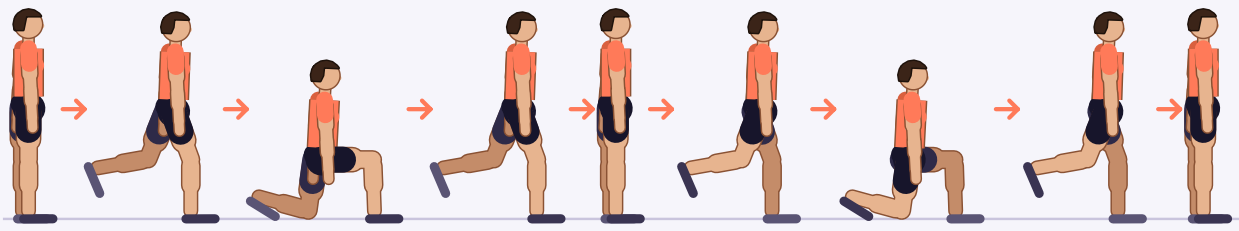
Squat

Feet shoulder-width apart, arms straight out in front, lower as if sitting down, thighs at least parallel to the floor, then stand up. When it gets easy: a weighted backpack held tight against your chest.

With a band: Band under your feet, held at your shoulders: it resists as you stand up.

Key points: Straight back, heels on the floor, knees in line with your feet.

Easier: Sit down on a chair and stand up.



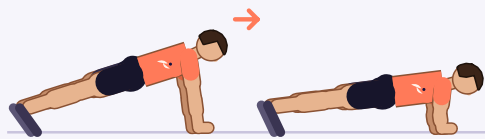
10 Reverse lunge

Step one leg back and lower until the back knee almost touches the floor. Come back by pushing through the front leg, then switch legs (the front foot stays planted). When it gets easy: a weighted backpack.

With a band: Band under your front foot, held at your shoulders.

Key points: Upright trunk, front knee above the ankle.

Easier: With support (wall, chair).



11 Push-ups

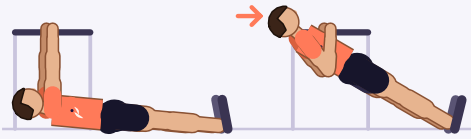
Hands slightly wider than your shoulders, body braced, lower your chest close to the floor then push. Harder: feet raised on a chair.

With a band: Band across your back, held under each hand: it resists as you push.

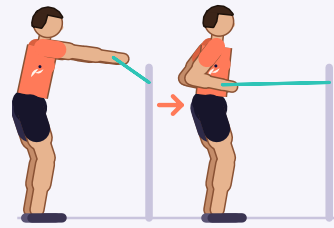
Key points: Elbows at 45° from your body, the hips do not sag.

Easier: Hands on a table, or knees on the floor.

At home



With a band

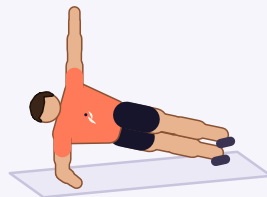


12 Inverted row

Lying under a sturdy table, hands on the edge, body straight: pull your chest towards the table, then lower. Other option: one-arm row with a weighted backpack.

With a band: Band anchored to a door at chest height: pull your elbows back.

Key points: Pull with your back, the shoulder blade moves towards the spine.

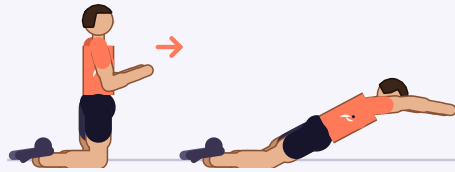


13 Side plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder) and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high, top arm reaching up to the ceiling.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.

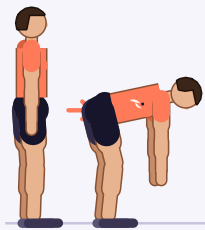


14 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a cushion, feet anchored under the sofa or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

Easier: Shorter descent.

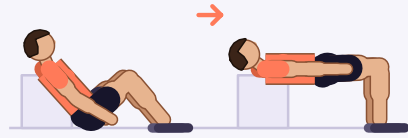


15 Romanian deadlift

Feet hip-width apart, knees slightly bent: tip your trunk forward by pushing your hips back, flat back, until you feel the stretch behind your thighs, then stand up. Harder: on one leg (the other goes back), or a bag in your hand.

With a band: On both legs, band under your feet, held with both hands: tip your trunk forward, flat back, and stand up.

Key points: Flat back from start to finish, the load slides along your legs.



16 Hip thrust

Upper back against the sofa, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line. When it gets easy: on one leg.

With a band: Band across your hips, held to the floor by your hands on each side.

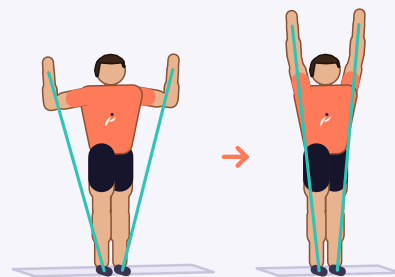
Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top for one second. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.

Easier: Glute bridge on the floor.

At home



With a band



17 Pike push-ups

Hands on the floor, hips up (body in an upside-down V): bend your elbows to bring the top of your head towards the floor, then push.

With a band: Standing on the band, press it overhead, then lower back to your shoulders.

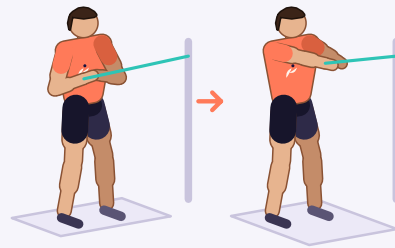
Key points: Tight core, do not arch your lower back.

Easier: Feet closer to your hands, shorter range.

At home



With a band

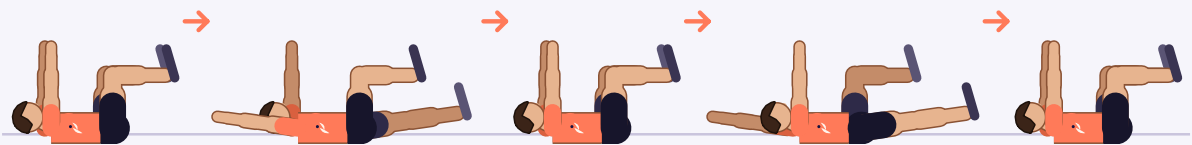


18 Plank with shoulder taps

In a straight-arm plank, feet apart: touch the opposite shoulder with one hand, then the other, without your hips moving.

With a band: Pallof press: band anchored to the side at chest height, press your arms out in front of you without letting your trunk rotate.

Key points: Resist the rotation: this is a core exercise.



19 Dead bug

On your back, arms straight up towards the ceiling, knees bent at 90°. Extend one arm and the opposite leg without touching the floor, then switch sides.

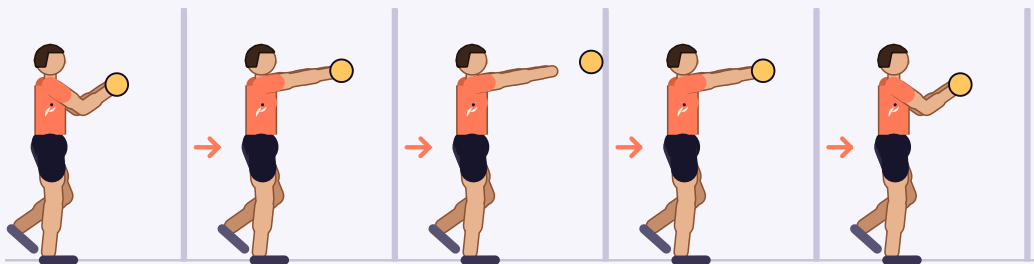
Key points: Your lower back stays pressed to the floor.



20 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

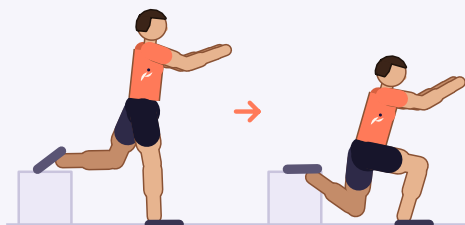
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



21 Balance with a ball

On one leg, throw a ball against a wall and catch it. Harder: standing on a folded cushion.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line.

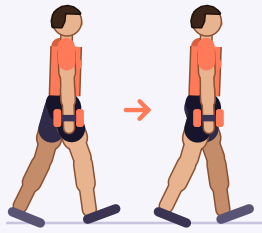


22 Bulgarian split squat

Back foot resting on the sofa or a chair, lower on the front leg then stand back up. When it gets easy: a weighted backpack.

With a band: Band under your front foot, held at your shoulders.

Key points: The front leg does the work, the back foot is only for balance.

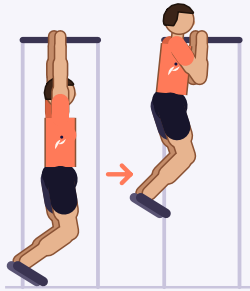


23 Farmer's walk

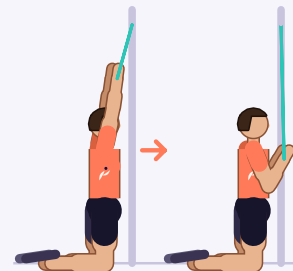
Walk with a heavy load in each hand: shopping bags, packs of water or water containers. If it is too light, double the distance.

Key points: Shoulders down, upright trunk, steady steps.

At home



With a band



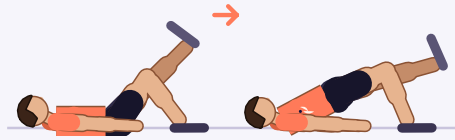
24 Pull-ups

On a doorway bar: hanging, pull until your chin is over the bar, then lower. Without a bar: inverted row under a table.

With a band: Kneeling, band anchored high: pull your elbows down, close to your body. With a bar: the band under your knees to help you.

Key points: Controlled descent, arms almost straight at the bottom.

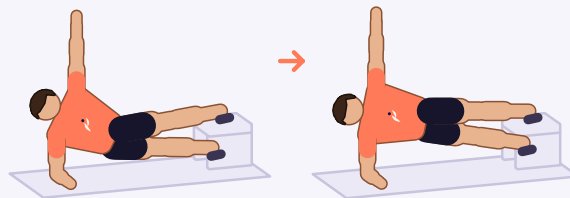
Easier: With a band, or only the slow descent.



25 Single-leg glute bridge

Like the glute bridge, with one leg straight in the air.

Key points: The pelvis stays level. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.

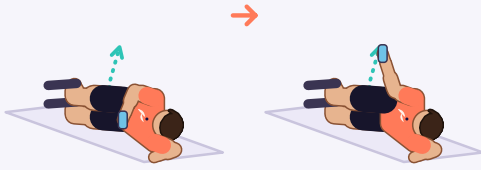


26 Copenhagen plank

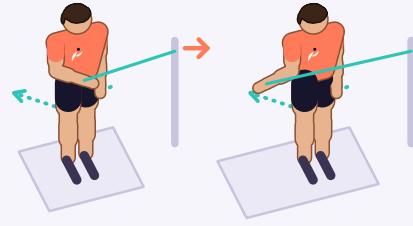
On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder), top leg resting on the sofa or a chair (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips, reach your top arm up to the ceiling and hold the position.

Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.

At home



With a band



27 Shoulder external rotation

Lying on your side, top elbow tucked against your waist and bent at 90°, a water bottle in your hand, forearm resting in front of your belly: lift your forearm towards the ceiling by pivoting around the elbow (the hand moves away from your belly), then lower slowly.

With a band: Standing, band anchored to the side: elbow tucked in, move your forearm outwards.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

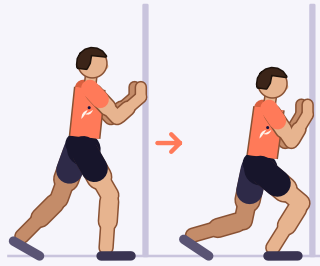
Easier: Without a band.



28 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

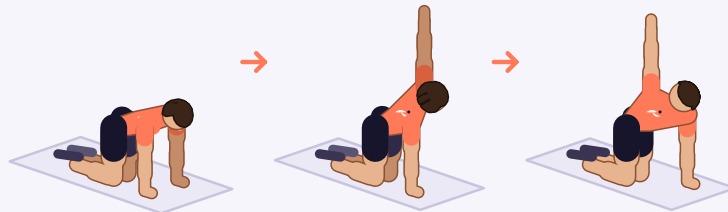
Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.



29 Ankle mobility at the wall

Facing a wall, hands on it, front foot 10 cm from the wall and the other foot behind: drive your front knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

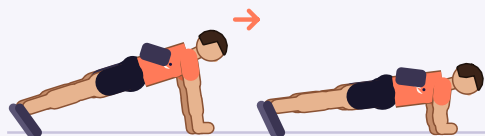
Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.



30 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

Key points: The pelvis does not move.



31 Weighted push-ups

Push-ups with a weighted backpack. Without a bag: feet raised, 3-second descent.

With a band: Push-ups with a strong band across your back.

Key points: Shoulder blades squeezed, explosive push.